

13

Chigorin and Zaitsev Systems

...Na5-c5 counterplay, ...Bb7 pressure, and the move-order details around White's center.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will compare two classical Spanish defenses by their piece routes and freeing breaks.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate candidates for the side to move, identify the opponent's strongest resource, and choose the resulting structure you can explain. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 073 | PAGE 4

Decode: Chigorin ...Na5 and ...c5*A gain of bishop tempo is temporary; budget a route for the knight.*

LESSON 074 | PAGE 8

Play: Chigorin ...Na5 and ...c5*A gain of bishop tempo is temporary; budget a route for the knight.*

LESSON 075 | PAGE 12

Decode: Zaitsev bishop pressure*Pressure matters when it changes the opponent's move; otherwise improve the worst piece.*

LESSON 076 | PAGE 16

Play: Zaitsev bishop pressure*Pressure matters when it changes the opponent's move; otherwise improve the worst piece.*

LESSON 077 | PAGE 20

Decode: Comparing the two systems*A system is a coordinated package; do not collect its moves one at a time.*

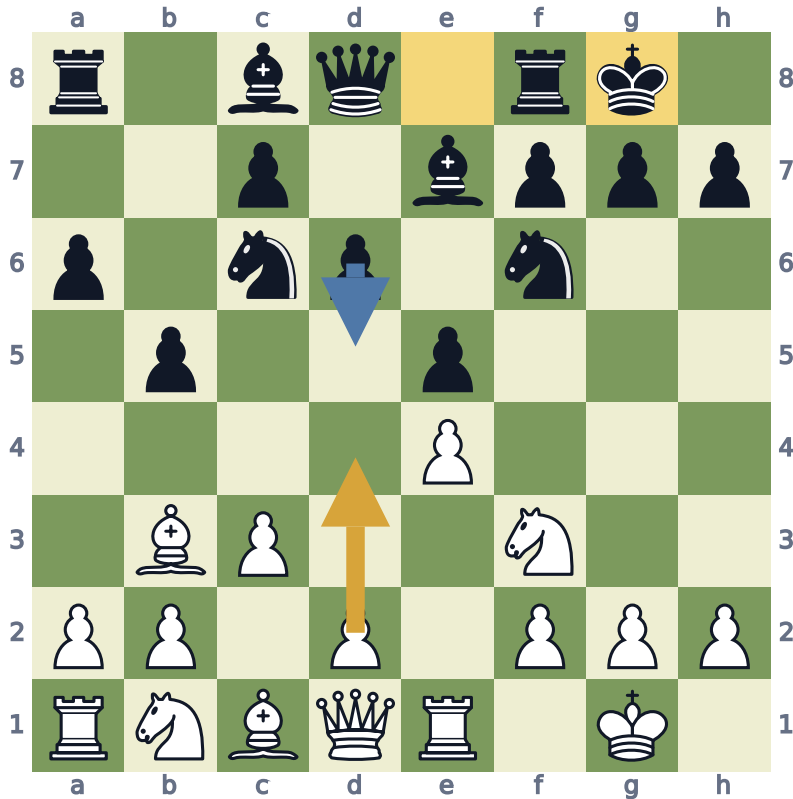
LESSON 078 | PAGE 24

Play: Comparing the two systems*A system is a coordinated package; do not collect its moves one at a time.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will compare two classical Spanish defenses by their piece routes and freeing breaks.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Chigorin ...Na5 and ...c5



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black gains the bishop retreat and attacks White's center with ...c5, accepting that the a5 knight may need a later route.

DECISION RULE

After ...c5, where is the a5 knight's next useful square and what happens if the center closes?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Use queenside space and c-file pressure, then reroute the a5 knight before it becomes irrelevant.

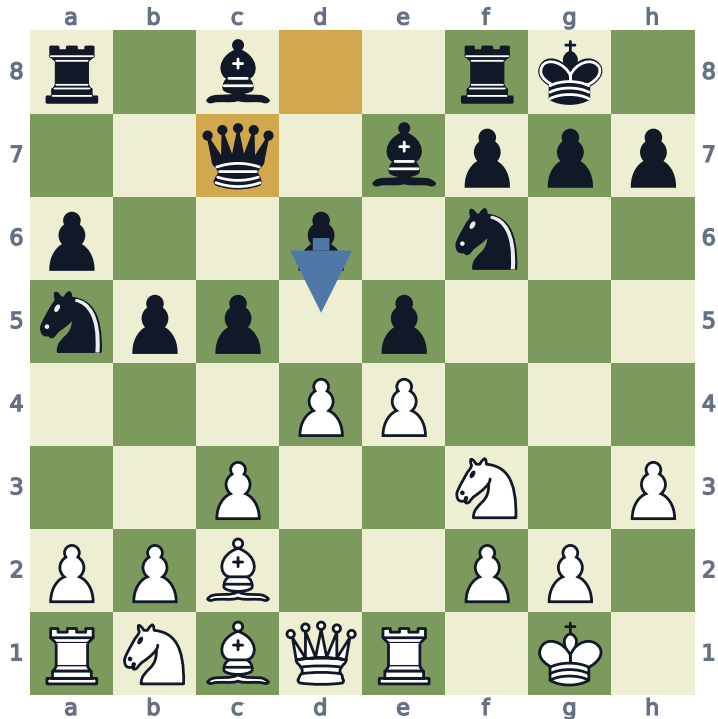
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White builds d4, may play d5, and uses the a5 knight's distance from the kingside.

MEMORY RULE | A gain of bishop tempo is temporary; budget a route for the knight.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black gains the bishop retreat and attacks White's center with ...c5, accepting that the a5 knight may need a later route.

BLACK'S PLAN

Use queenside space and c-file pressure, then reroute the a5 knight before it becomes irrelevant.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White builds d4, may play d5, and uses the a5 knight's distance from the kingside.

FAILURE MODE

Completing ...Na5-c5 by habit while the knight has no return route.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After ...c5, where is the a5 knight's next useful square and what happens if the center closes? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

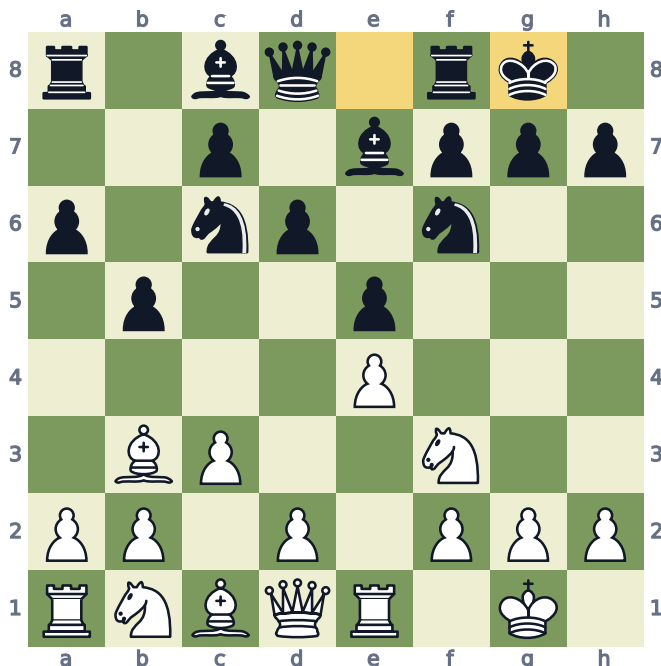
RULE | A gain of bishop tempo is temporary; budget a route for the knight.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Na5 10. Bc2 c5 11. d4 Qc7



- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.
- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- c3: White supports d4 and reserves c2 as a retreat square for the Spanish bishop.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black gains the bishop retreat and attacks White's center with ...c5, accepting that the a5 knight may need a later route.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After ...c5, where is the a5 knight's next useful square and what happens if the center closes? White's resource is: White builds d4, may play d5, and uses the a5 knight's distance from the kingside. The line fails as a template when: Completing ...Na5-c5 by habit while the knight has no return route.

STORE THIS | A gain of bishop tempo is temporary; budget a route for the knight.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

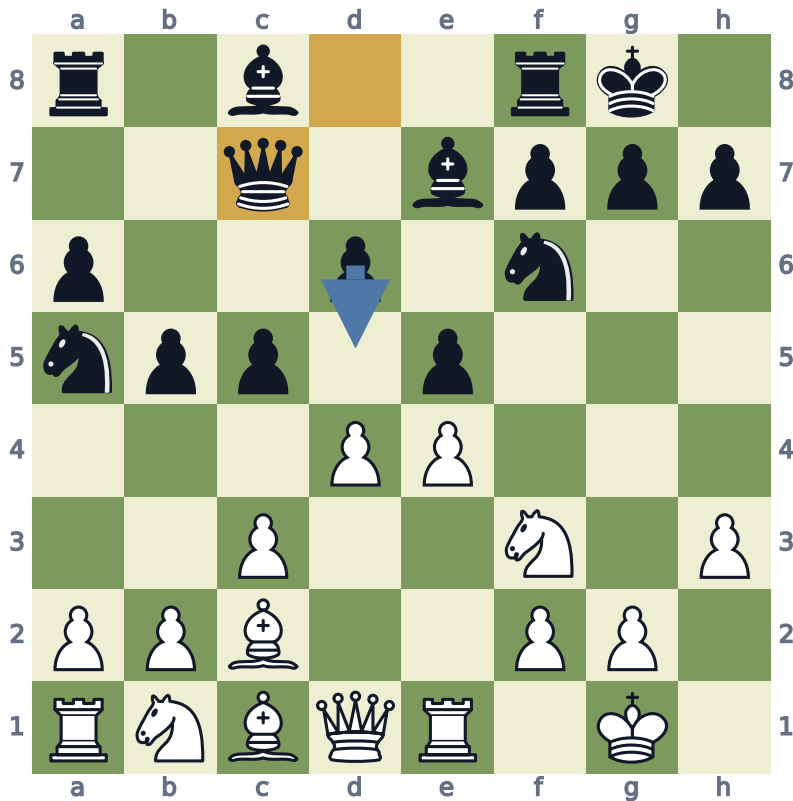
1. Black gains the bishop retreat and attacks White's center with ...c5, accepting that the a5 knight may need a later route. 2. Use queenside space and c-file pressure, then reroute the a5 knight before it becomes irrelevant. 3. White builds d4, may play d5, and uses the a5 knight's distance from the kingside. 4. After ...c5, where is the a5 knight's next useful square and what happens if the center closes? 5. Completing ...Na5-c5 by habit while the knight has no return route.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Chigorin ...Na5 and ...c5



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black gains the bishop retreat and attacks White's center with ...c5, accepting that the a5 knight may need a later route.

DECISION RULE

After ...c5, where is the a5 knight's next useful square and what happens if the center closes?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

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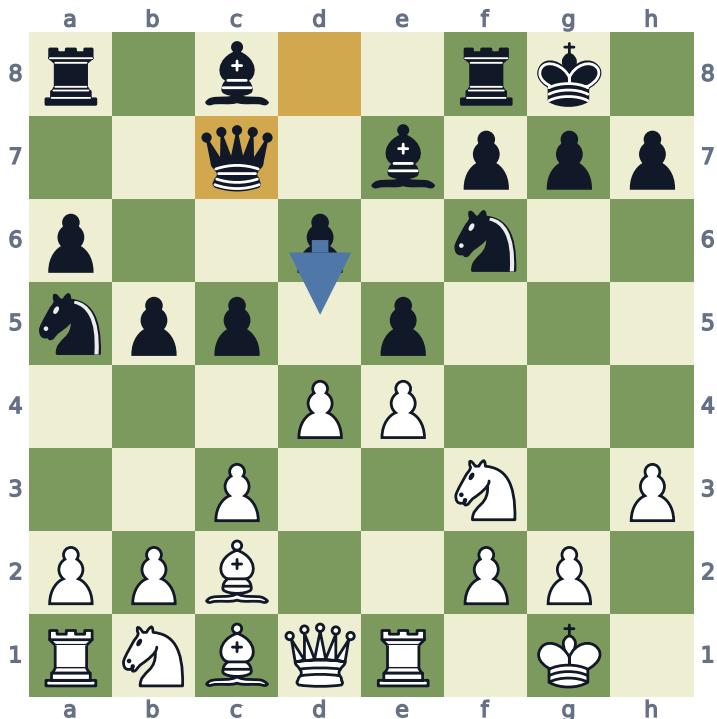
WHITE'S RESOURCES

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MEMORY RULE | A gain of bishop tempo is temporary; budget a route for the knight.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black gains the bishop retreat and attacks White's center with ...c5, accepting that the a5 knight may need a later route.

BLACK'S PLAN

Use queenside space and c-file pressure, then reroute the a5 knight before it becomes irrelevant.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White builds d4, may play d5, and uses the a5 knight's distance from the kingside.

FAILURE MODE

Completing ...Na5-c5 by habit while the knight has no return route.

DECISION TEST

Ask: After ...c5, where is the a5 knight's next useful square and what happens if the center closes? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

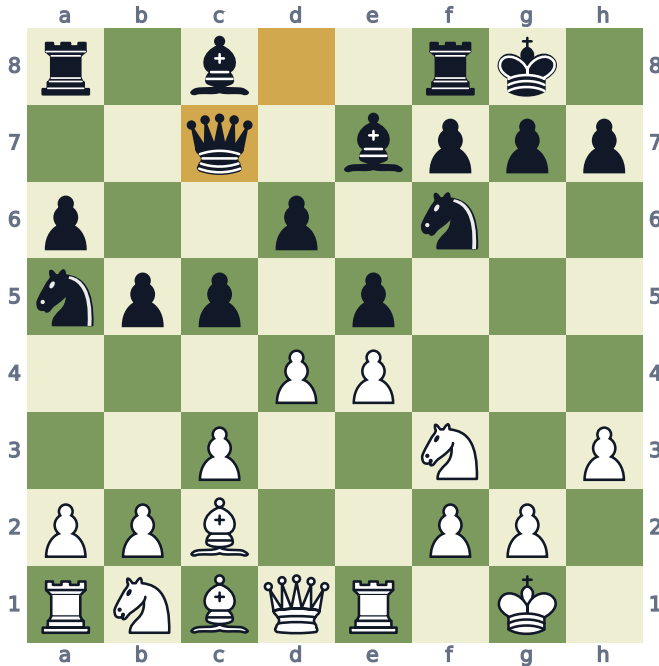
RULE | A gain of bishop tempo is temporary; budget a route for the knight.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- h3: White prevents a pin and supports the coming central plan at the cost of one tempo.
- Na5: Black reroutes a knight to a5; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Bc2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- c5: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- d4: White challenges e5 and opens lines after the preparatory pieces are ready.
- Qc7: Black coordinates several plans, but the queen's safety and the opponent's forcing reply must be checked.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black gains the bishop retreat and attacks White's center with ...c5, accepting that the a5 knight may need a later route.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

After ...c5, where is the a5 knight's next useful square and what happens if the center closes? White's resource is: White builds d4, may play d5, and uses the a5 knight's distance from the kingside. The line fails as a template when: Completing ...Na5-c5 by habit while the knight has no return route.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

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4. What exact question decides the next move?

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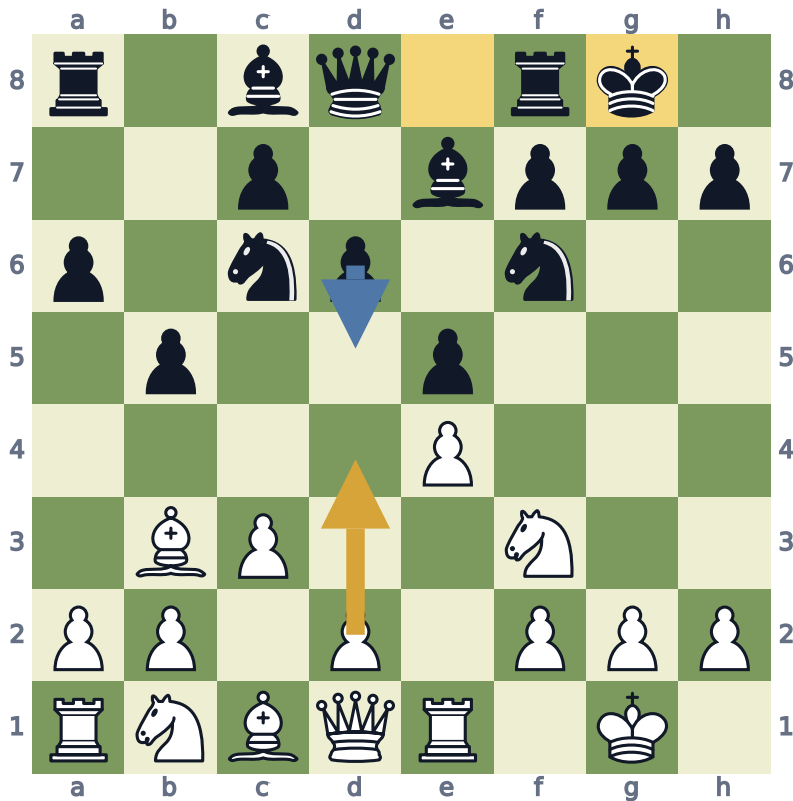
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 22 plies from memory, then replay: 9. h3 Na5 10. Bc2 c5 11. d4 Qc7

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Zaitsev bishop pressure

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

...Bb7 and ...Re8 intensify pressure on e4 and prepare active central play without retreating the c6 knight.

DECISION RULE

Does pressure on e4 create a real tactical obligation, or can White advance d5 with gain of time?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Coordinate the bishop and rook against e4, then use ...Bf8 and ...h6 or ...g6 to stabilize the king.

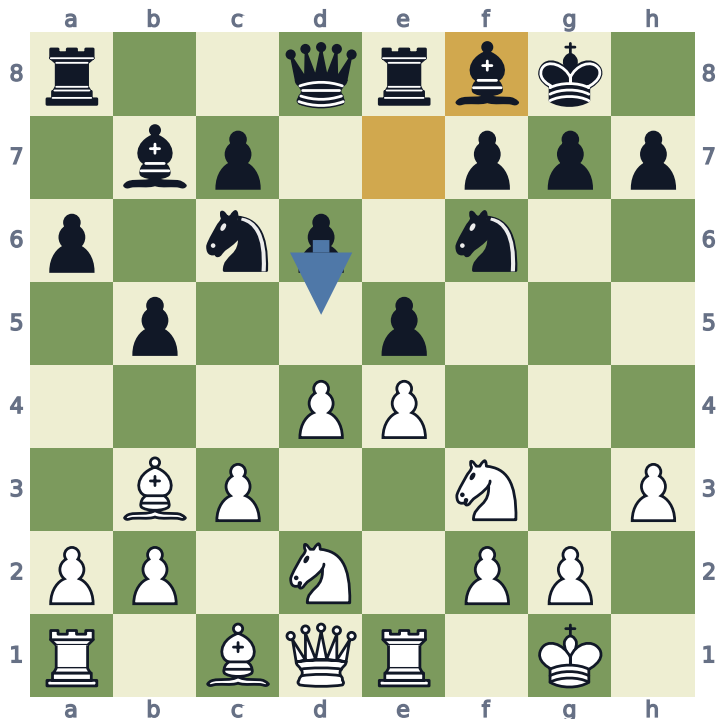
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White uses d5, a4, or Ng5 ideas to exploit the exposed long diagonal and move order.

MEMORY RULE | Pressure matters when it changes the opponent's move; otherwise improve the worst piece.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...Bb7 and ...Re8 intensify pressure on e4 and prepare active central play without retreating the c6 knight.

BLACK'S PLAN

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White uses d5, a4, or Ng5 ideas to exploit the exposed long diagonal and move order.

FAILURE MODE

Adding attackers to e4 while ignoring White's central advance or repetition resources.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does pressure on e4 create a real tactical obligation, or can White advance d5 with gain of time? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

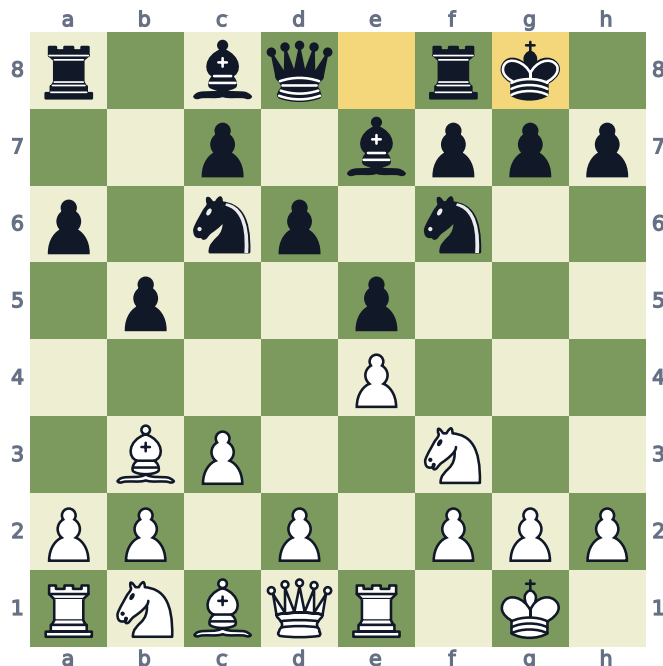
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Move-by-move meaning

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- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
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Does pressure on e4 create a real tactical obligation, or can White advance d5 with gain of time? White's resource is: White uses d5, a4, or Ng5 ideas to exploit the exposed long diagonal and move order. The line fails as a template when: Adding attackers to e4 while ignoring White's central advance or repetition resources.

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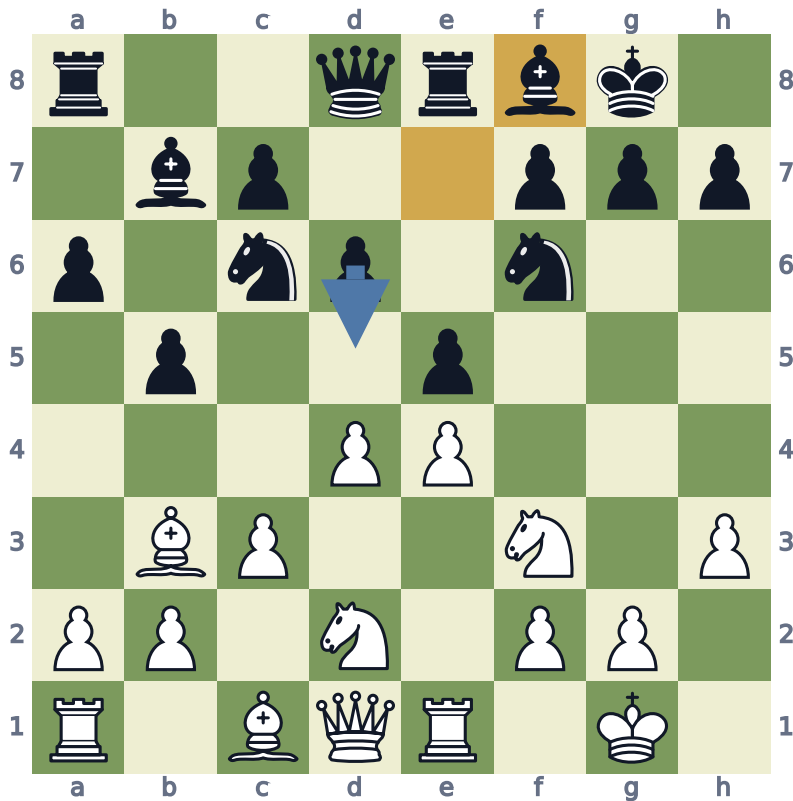
1. ...Bb7 and ...Re8 intensify pressure on e4 and prepare active central play without retreating the c6 knight. 2. Coordinate the bishop and rook against e4, then use ...Bf8 and ...h6 or ...g6 to stabilize the king. 3. White uses d5, a4, or Ng5 ideas to exploit the exposed long diagonal and move order. 4. Does pressure on e4 create a real tactical obligation, or can White advance d5 with gain of time? 5. Adding attackers to e4 while ignoring White's central advance or repetition resources.

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Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O

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Play: Zaitsev bishop pressure



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

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DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

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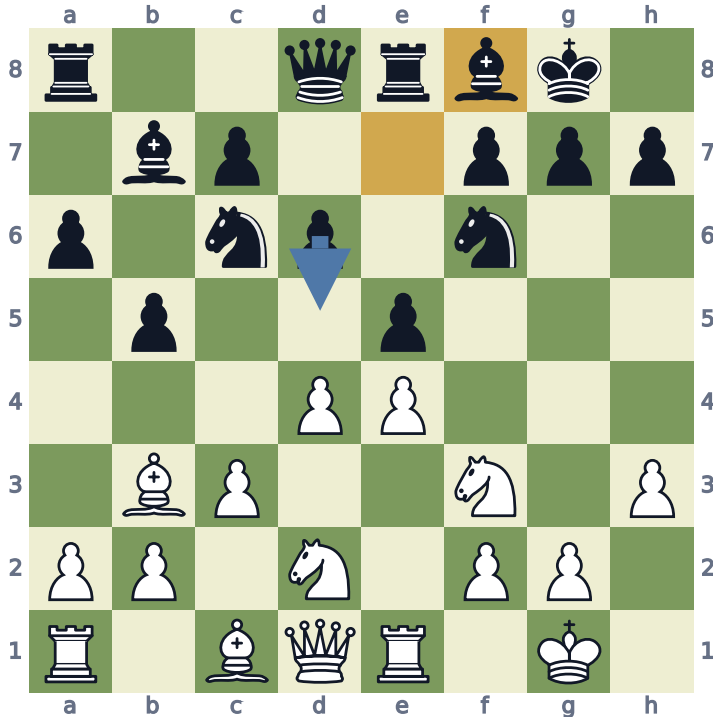
WHITE'S RESOURCES

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MEMORY RULE | Pressure matters when it changes the opponent's move; otherwise improve the worst piece.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK'S PLAN

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White uses d5, a4, or Ng5 ideas to exploit the exposed long diagonal and move order.

FAILURE MODE

Adding attackers to e4 while ignoring White's central advance or repetition resources.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does pressure on e4 create a real tactical obligation, or can White advance d5 with gain of time? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

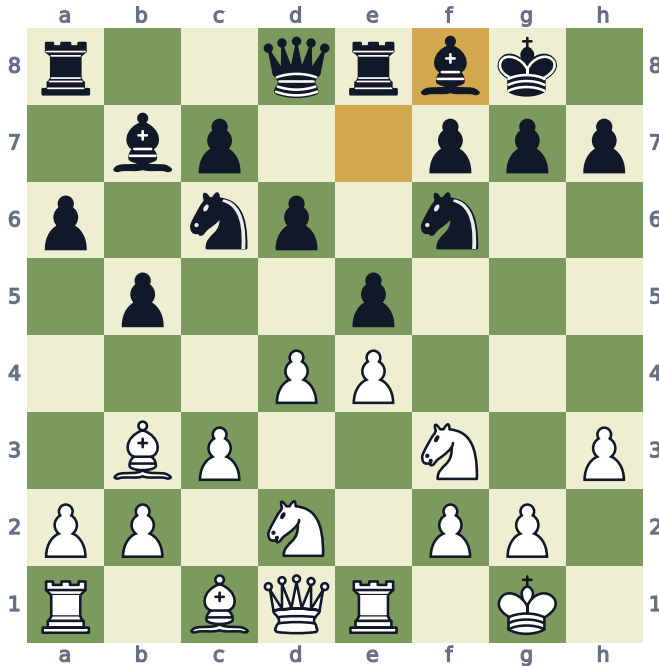
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

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- h3: White prevents a pin and supports the coming central plan at the cost of one tempo.
- Bb7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d4: White challenges e5 and opens lines after the preparatory pieces are ready.
- Re8: Black places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
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WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...Bb7 and ...Re8 intensify pressure on e4 and prepare active central play without retreating the c6 knight.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does pressure on e4 create a real tactical obligation, or can White advance d5 with gain of time? White's resource is: White uses d5, a4, or Ng5 ideas to exploit the exposed long diagonal and move order. The line fails as a template when: Adding attackers to e4 while ignoring White's central advance or repetition resources.

STORE THIS | Pressure matters when it changes the opponent's move; otherwise improve the worst piece.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

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4. What exact question decides the next move?

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ANSWER KEY

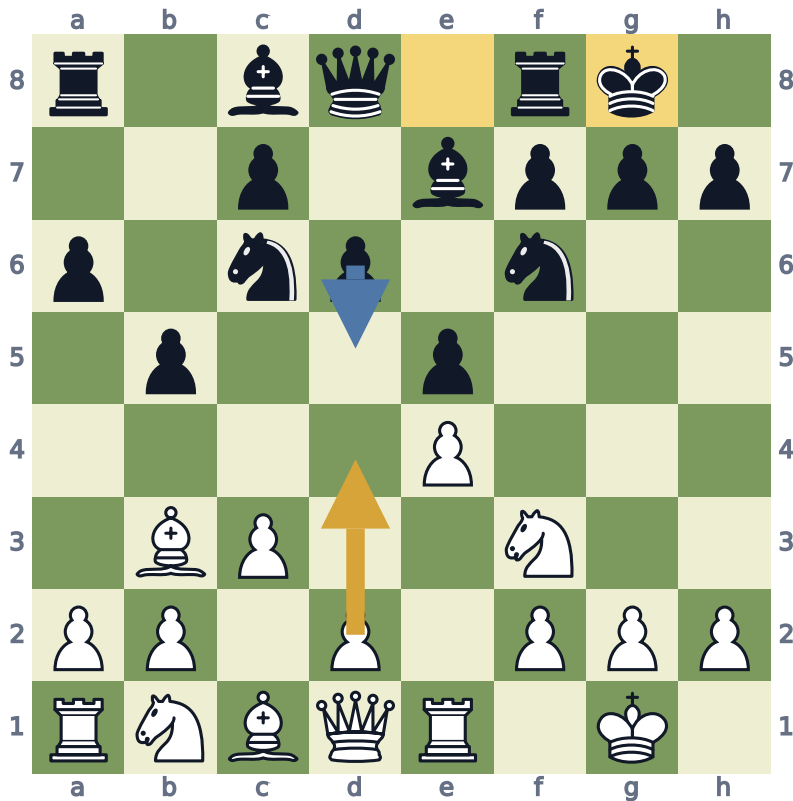
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Rebuild the position after 22 plies from memory, then replay: 9. h3 Bb7 10. d4 Re8 11. Nbd2 Bf8

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Comparing the two systems



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Chigorin creates immediate queenside and c-file play; Zaitsev keeps more central pressure and piece tension. The choice changes the long-term knight problem.

DECISION RULE

Which black knight or bishop will be worst after the center closes?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Select the system whose piece route and central break match the current move order, not merely personal taste.

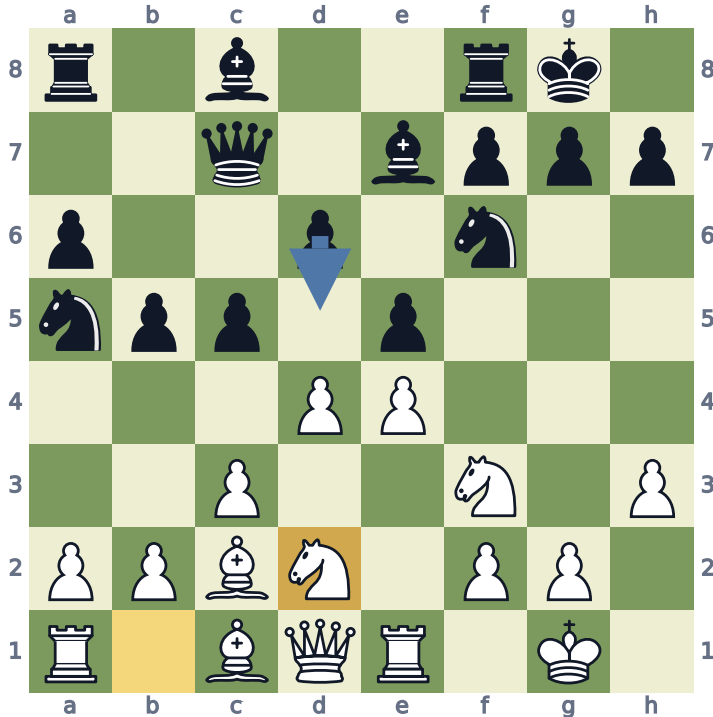
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White adapts the center: d5 against queenside play, or tactical pressure against e4-focused pieces.

MEMORY RULE | A system is a coordinated package; do not collect its moves one at a time.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



WHITE'S PLAN

White adapts the center: d5 against queenside play, or tactical pressure against e4-focused pieces.

CUE

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BLACK'S PLAN

Select the system whose piece route and central break match the current move order, not merely personal taste.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

FAILURE MODE

Mixing moves from both systems and producing a position where neither plan works fully.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which black knight or bishop will be worst after the center closes? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

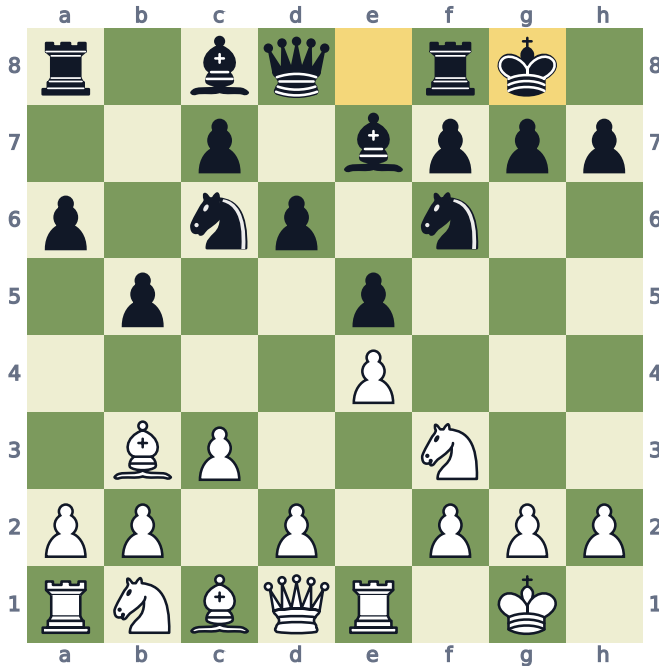
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

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WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

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WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

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ANSWER KEY

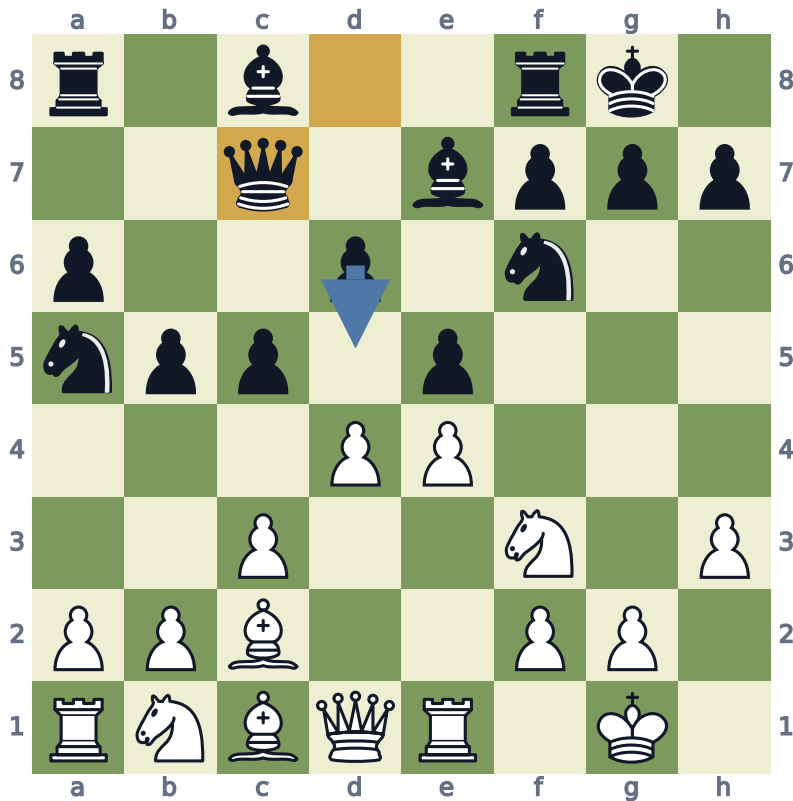
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Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Comparing the two systems



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DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

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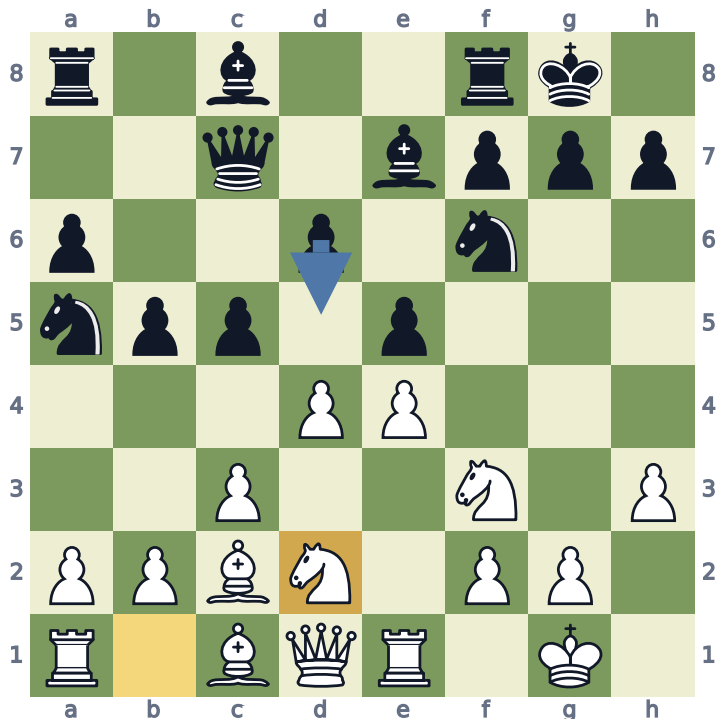
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



WHITE'S PLAN

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CUE

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

Black

FAILURE MODE

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DECISION TEST

Ask: Which black knight or bishop will be worst after the center closes? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

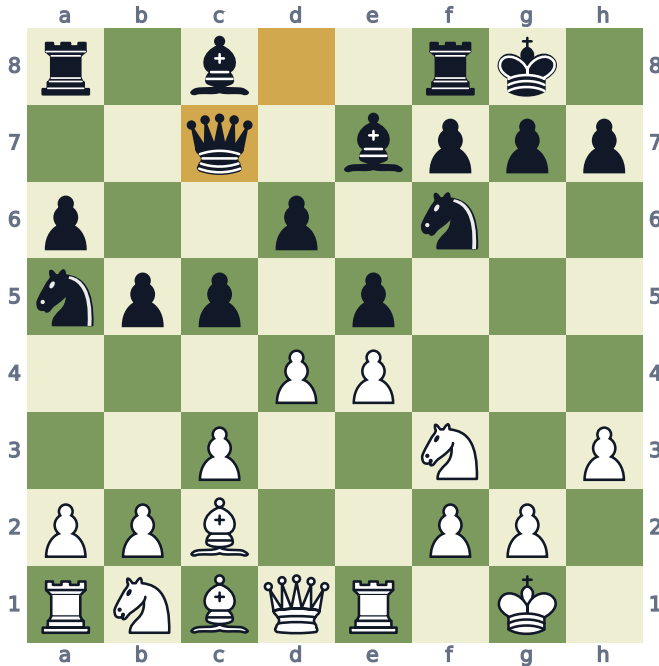
RULE | A system is a coordinated package; do not collect its moves one at a time.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Na5 10. Bc2 c5 11. d4 Qc7 12. Nbd2



- h3: White prevents a pin and supports the coming central plan at the cost of one tempo.
- Na5: Black reroutes a knight to a5; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Bc2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- c5: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- d4: White challenges e5 and opens lines after the preparatory pieces are ready.
- Qc7: Black coordinates several plans, but the queen's safety and the opponent's forcing reply must be checked.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Chigorin creates immediate queenside and c-file play; Zaitsev keeps more central pressure and piece tension. The choice changes the long-term knight problem.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which black knight or bishop will be worst after the center closes? White's resource is: White adapts the center: d5 against queenside play, or tactical pressure against e4-focused pieces. The line fails as a template when: Mixing moves from both systems and producing a position where neither plan works fully.

STORE THIS | A system is a coordinated package; do not collect its moves one at a time.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Chigorin creates immediate queenside and c-file play; Zaitsev keeps more central pressure and piece tension. The choice changes the long-term knight problem. 2. Select the system whose piece route and central break match the current move order, not merely personal taste. 3. White adapts the center: d5 against queenside play, or tactical pressure against e4-focused pieces. 4. Which black knight or bishop will be worst after the center closes? 5. Mixing moves from both systems and producing a position where neither plan works fully.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 22 plies from memory, then replay: 9. h3 Na5 10. Bc2 c5 11. d4 Qc7

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 073 Decode: Chigorin ...Na5 and ...c5

Prompt: After ...c5, where is the a5 knight's next useful square and what happens if the center closes?

Recall: A gain of bishop tempo is temporary; budget a route for the knight.

LESSON 074 Play: Chigorin ...Na5 and ...c5

Prompt: After ...c5, where is the a5 knight's next useful square and what happens if the center closes?

Recall: A gain of bishop tempo is temporary; budget a route for the knight.

LESSON 075 Decode: Zaitsev bishop pressure

Prompt: Does pressure on e4 create a real tactical obligation, or can White advance d5 with gain of time?

Recall: Pressure matters when it changes the opponent's move; otherwise improve the worst piece.

LESSON 076 Play: Zaitsev bishop pressure

Prompt: Does pressure on e4 create a real tactical obligation, or can White advance d5 with gain of time?

Recall: Pressure matters when it changes the opponent's move; otherwise improve the worst piece.

LESSON 077 Decode: Comparing the two systems

Prompt: Which black knight or bishop will be worst after the center closes?

Recall: A system is a coordinated package; do not collect its moves one at a time.

LESSON 078 Play: Comparing the two systems

Prompt: Which black knight or bishop will be worst after the center closes?

Recall: A system is a coordinated package; do not collect its moves one at a time.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's plan, one candidate for the side to move, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Chigorin ...Na5 and ...c5

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Na5 10. Bc2 c5 11. d4 Qc7

Decision: After ...c5, where is the a5 knight's next useful square and what happens if the center closes?

Memory: A gain of bishop tempo is temporary; budget a route for the knight.

CARD 2

Zaitsev bishop pressure

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Bb7 10. d4 Re8 11. Nbd2 Bf8

Decision: Does pressure on e4 create a real tactical obligation, or can White advance d5 with gain of time?

Memory: Pressure matters when it changes the opponent's move; otherwise improve the worst piece.

CARD 3

Comparing the two systems

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Na5 10. Bc2 c5 11. d4 Qc7 12. Nbd2

Decision: Which black knight or bishop will be worst after the center closes?

Memory: A system is a coordinated package; do not collect its moves one at a time.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
073 Decode: Chigorin ...Na5 and ...c5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
074 Play: Chigorin ...Na5 and ...c5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
075 Decode: Zaitsev bishop pressure	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
076 Play: Zaitsev bishop pressure	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
077 Decode: Comparing the two systems	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
078 Play: Comparing the two systems	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name both sides' strongest plans, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.